SCAN ME

Echoes in the Sky

Computational thematic analysis of Bluesky discourse around Trump's reelection.









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Why Bluesky?

- Trump’s return to office created a concentrated period of policy change.

- Executive orders (EOs) provide a policy timeline for interpreting shifts in attention.

- Bluesky’s open ecosystem makes political conversation observable at scale.



Research questions

01 Which themes structure Trump-related discussion on Bluesky, and what sentiment accompanies them?

02 How do these themes evolve over time, and do major shifts coincide with executive orders (EOs)?

Method overview

A **Data construction**

38.5M posts → 30.2M cleaned

B **Microtopic discovery**

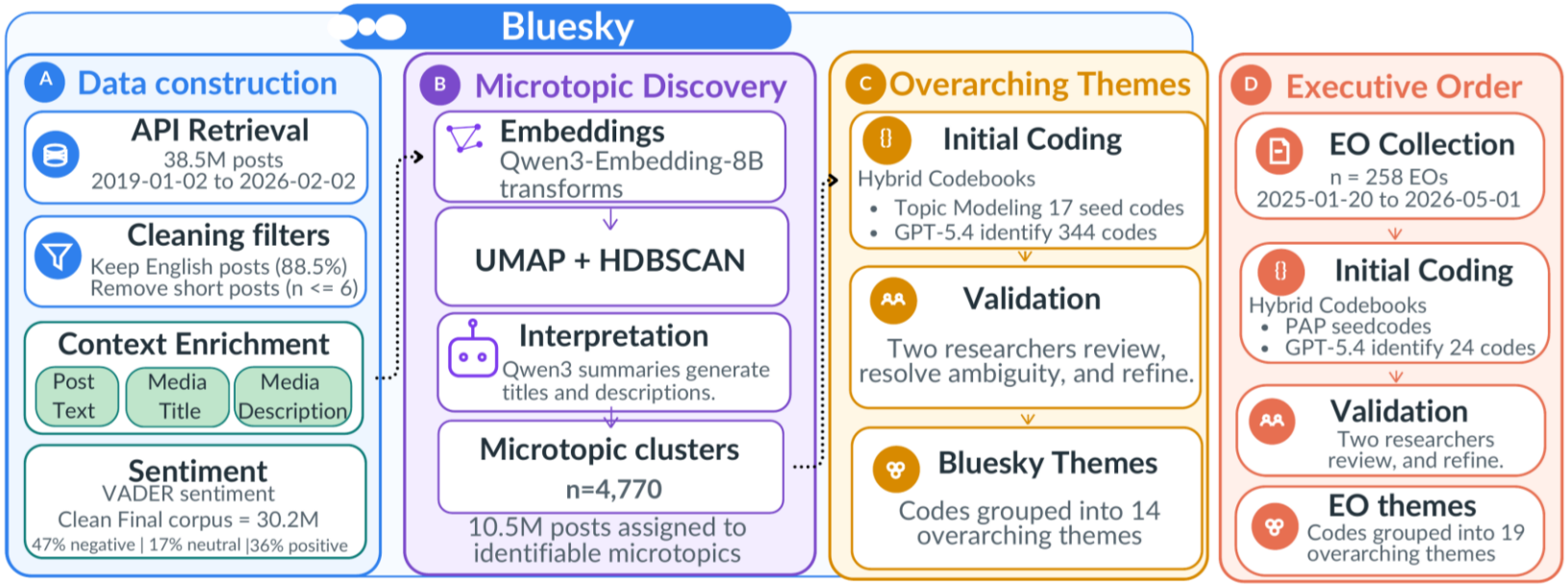
10.5M posts → 4,770 clusters

C **Overarching themes**

344 initial codes → 14 themes

D **EO comparison**

258 EOs → 19 EO themes



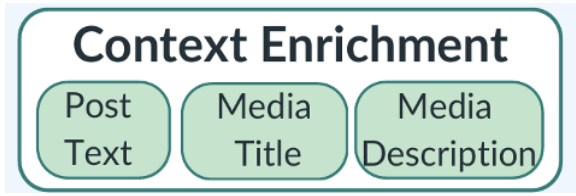
Data collection

- **Historical retrieval** (via app.bsky.feed.searchPosts)

- **Keywords** based queries: *Trump, MAGA, Trumpism, POTUS45, America First*, and related terms

- **API cap**: 100 result pages (~10,000 posts); sliding time windows improved coverage

Data collection



38.5M

raw data

1.36M

unique authors

Preprocessing
remove short post (n<=6)
English post (88.5%)

30.2M

English-language cleaned dataset

JAN 2, 2019

JAN 20, 2025
Trump second term begins

FEB 2, 2026

Sentiment analysis (VADER)

35.7%

positive

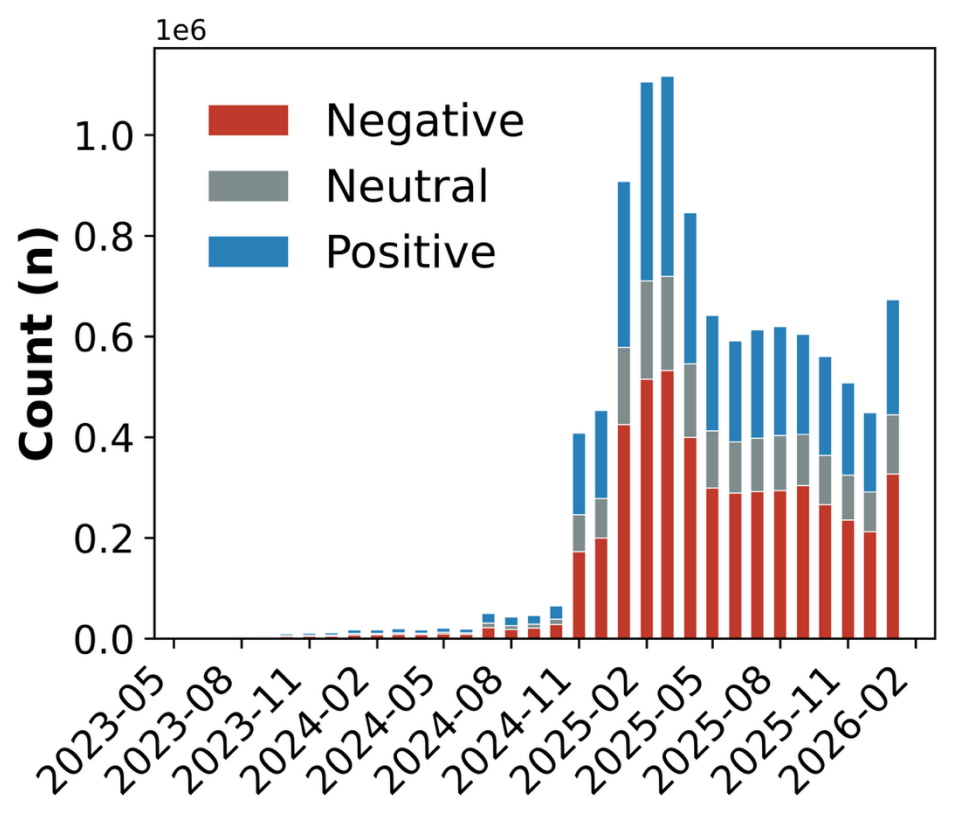
17.3%

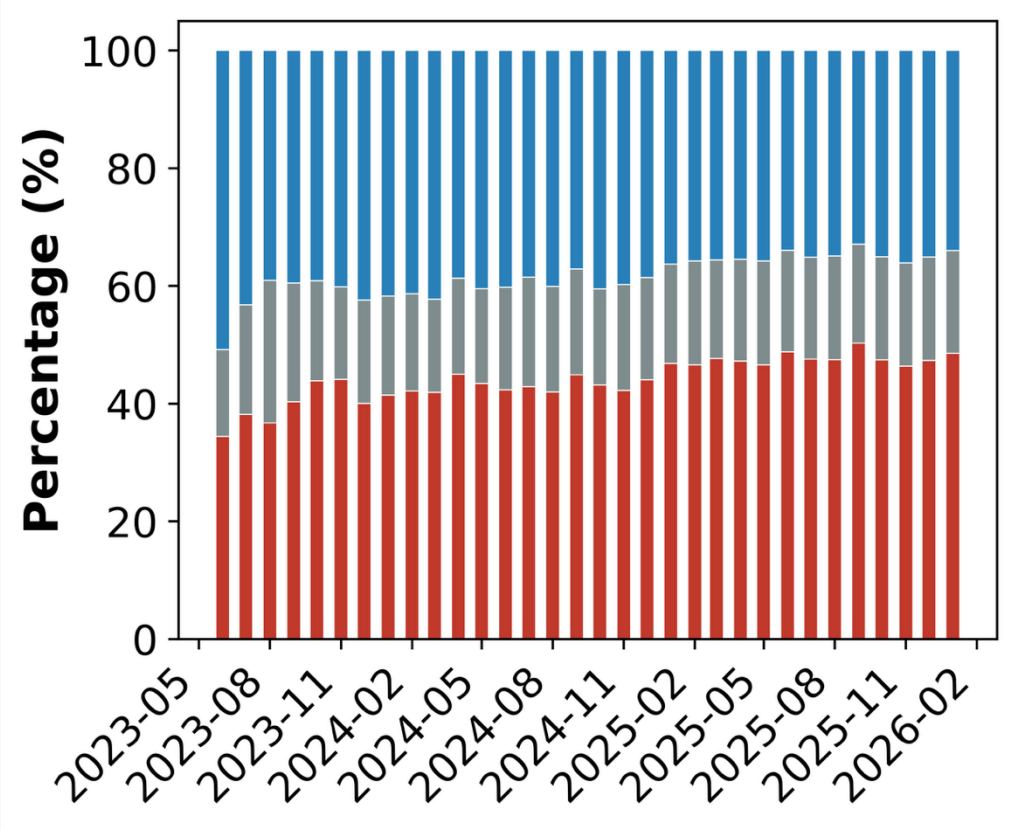
neutral

47.0%

negative

Negativity widens over time





Microtopics preserve fine-grained detail.

01 / Discover microtopics across all posts

Qwen3-Embedding-8B + UMAP + HDBSCAN identify clusters within four temporal partitions.

02 / Summarize every cluster

4,770 clusters cover 10.46M posts. Up to 100 representative posts generate each title and description by LLM.

Frequent microtopic examples

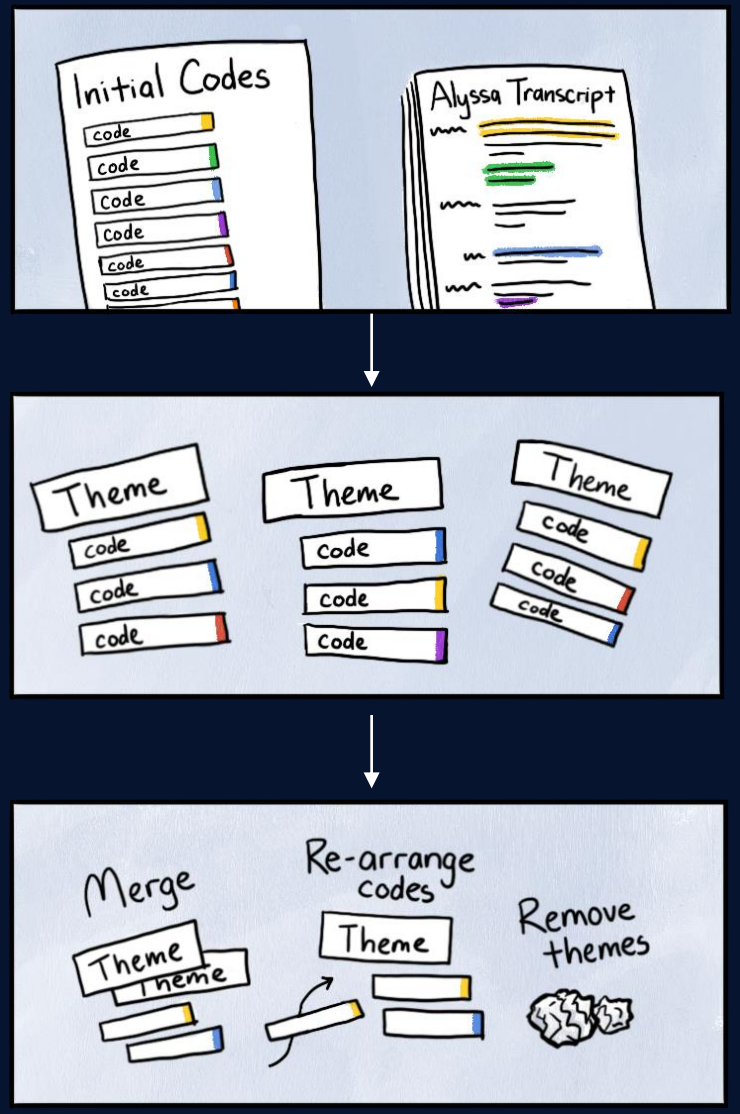
Part.	ID	Microtopic Summarization	Count
A	44	Trump's Gaza Takeover Plan and Its Consequences	184,591
D	567	Trump's Greenland Obsession and Global Backlash	80,573
B	303	Trump, Netanyahu, and the Gaza Crisis	77,184
B	576	Trump and Musk: Power, Paranoia, and Puppetry	52,766
A	809	Trump's TikTok Paradox: From Ban to Savior	47,579
A	35	Project 2025: Trump's Hidden Agenda	42,572
A	27	Trump Blames DEI for Plane Crash Amid Safety Cuts	42,206
C	1131	Trump's Erosion of Disaster Response Systems	39,904

Merging into higher level themes

03 / Code, review, consolidate

- Follow LLM-assisted Thematic Analysis approach (Wang et al., 2025)

- Hybrid Codebooks
  - *17 Seed codes* from initial topic modeling
  - GPT-5.4 mini guide
  - Two researchers refine *344 initial codes* into *14 themes*, assigning each microtopic one dominant theme.

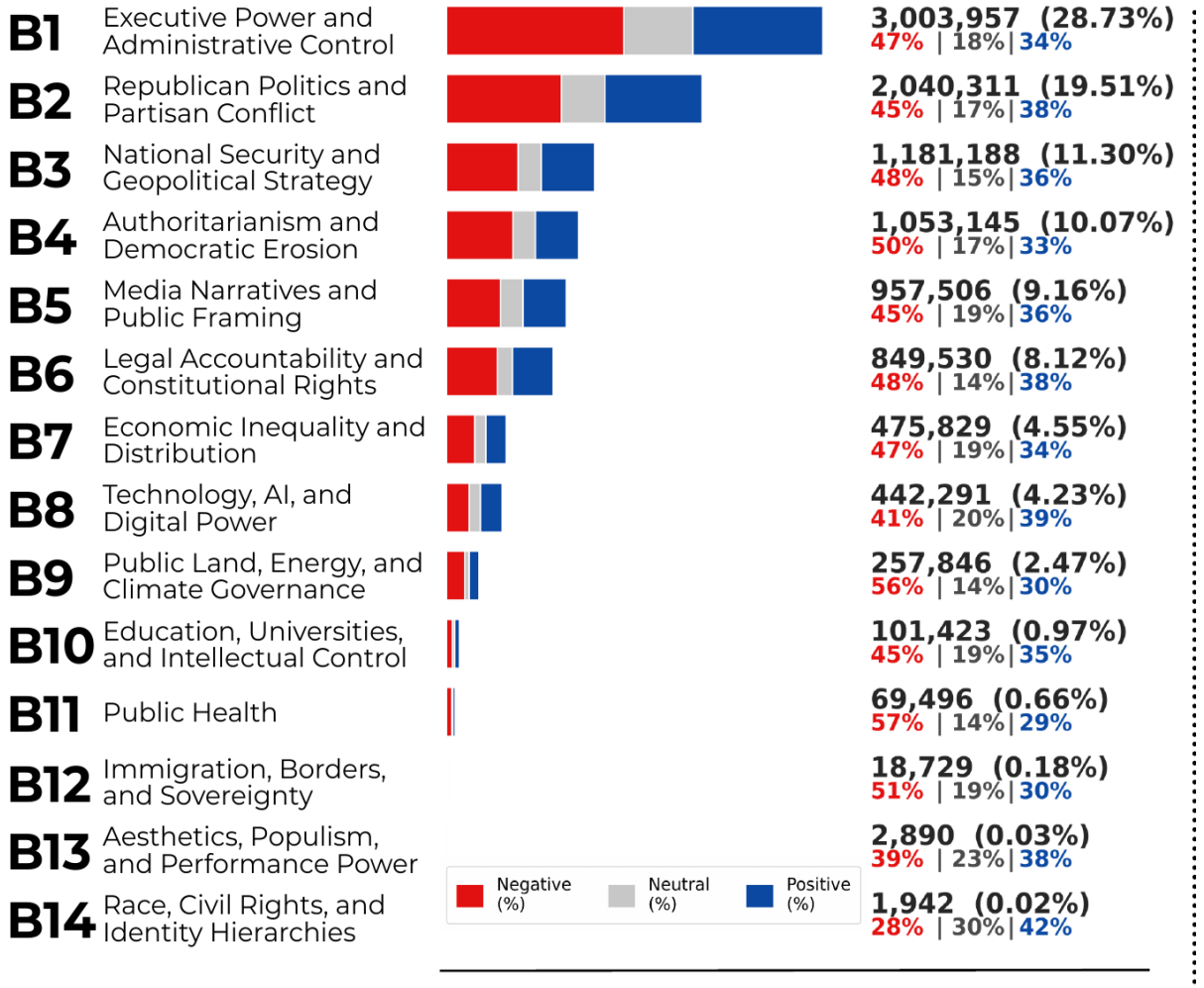


Five themes account for 78.8% of themes

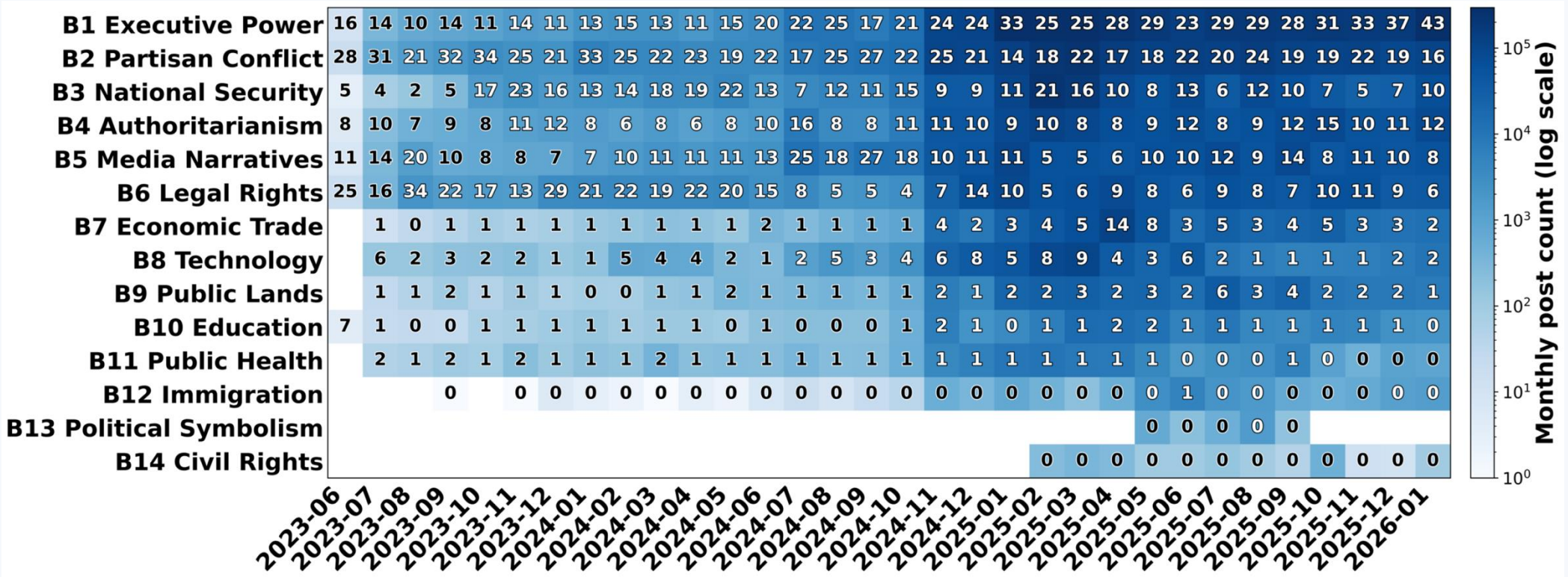
Executive Power	Partisan Conflict	National Security	Democratic Erosion	Media Narratives
28.73%	19.51%	11.30%	10.07%	9.16%

Other themes span legal accountability, economic inequality, technology and AI, climate governance, education, public health, immigration, political symbolism, and civil rights.

Overarching themes



Attention is both persistent and volatile.



The heatmap shows enduring high-attention themes alongside episodic spikes around contemporary events and policy developments.

Executive orders anchor a policy timeline.

258

executive orders
Jan. 20, 2025 – May 1, 2026

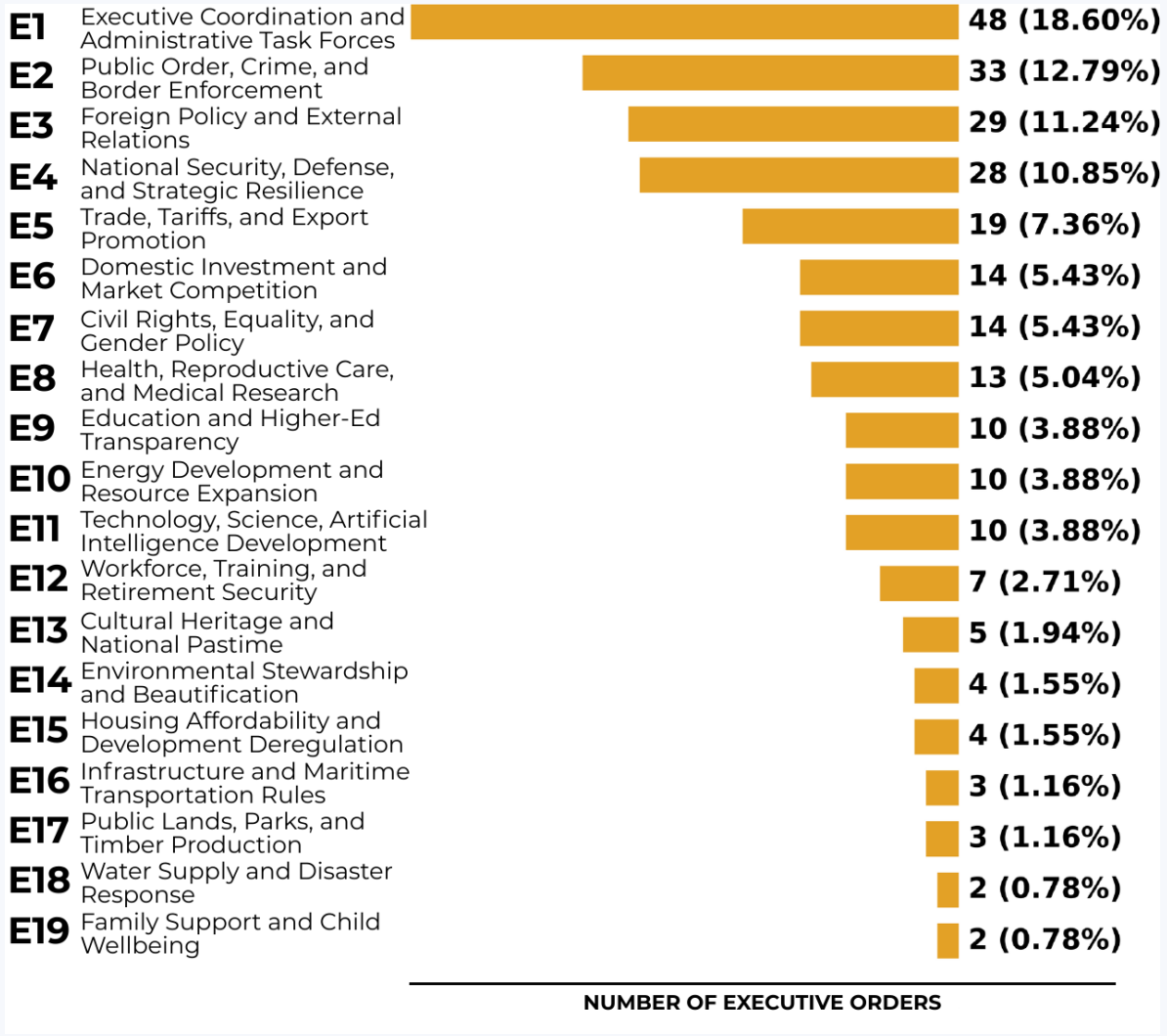
19

executive-order thematic categories

The comparison is interpretive: it helps situate shifts in Bluesky conversation alongside policy activity without collapsing correlation into causation.

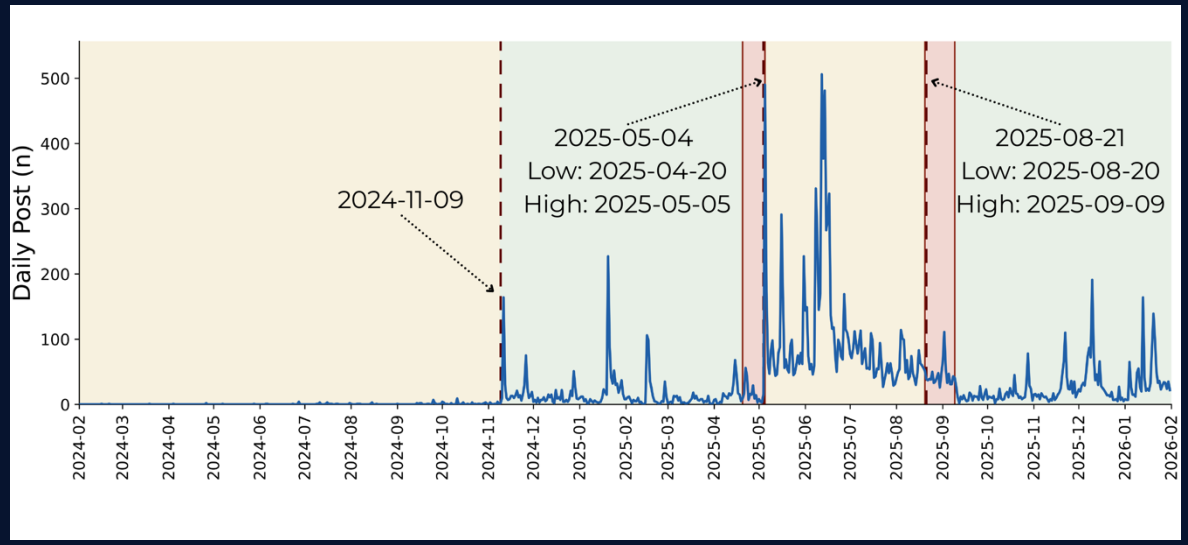
EO source: Federal Register Presidential Documents; coding follows a hybrid, validated procedure.

Executive-order themes



Immigration discourse moves through distinct attention regimes.

Structural-break analysis detects abrupt changes in immigration-related posting activity—not a smooth trend.



Breaks cluster around border-control executive actions and associated media attention.

A reusable framework for studying political discourse at scale.

01 / A large, longitudinal Bluesky corpus

38.5M Trump-related posts across the reelection and early second term.

02 / Human-validated thematic interpretation

LLM-assisted clustering is coupled with researcher review and refinement.

03 / A policy-aware temporal lens

Thematic trends and structural breaks are read alongside executive-order activity.

Future work: broader coverage, sharper inference.

Across platforms

Compare Bluesky with other platforms and a wider range of political conversations.

From valence to stance

Develop measures that distinguish emotional tone from political support or opposition.

From alignment to explanation

Test the mechanisms behind attention shifts rather than relying on temporal coincidence alone.